Companies are stealing SEO from smaller companies. There is no way to fix it; it’s a legal gray area.

We have recently noticed that a company is specifically targeting our (FTI Studio’s) SEO intentionally, and it is obvious to the team. They are copying our original technical concepts and article angles, just with slightly better SEO and AEO optimization, purely to market their own paid affiliates and sponsors. Now, if you directly search up our article titles on Google, their pages appear first instead of ours.

Early on, our team created specialized technical resources and targeted specific discovery channels to explain software mechanics and digital image editing workflows. Over time, we tracked search engine queries like "The Best Image Editors for Digital Art" where search engines, including AI Overview engines, actively referenced our structural content and cited our pages as primary technical sources.

Recently, that dynamic shifted. Our team observed that established media aggregators, specifically pages like Creative Bloq’s digital art software guide, began directly copying us. Even though it says July 9th of 2026, they edited their own article to copy us. Internet Archive link here. They copied our precise phrasing, directly made our article titles just slightly better than ours, and copied the specific structural angles we designed to explain software choices to digital artists. They did this because our original content was already ranking well and attracting high search traffic. By taking our exact format and wrapping it in their larger domain, they can steal our search traffic, plug in their paid sponsors, and push our original work down the page. When search engines generate summary results for these broad topics, they continue to pull the conceptual framework derived from smaller developer resources, but they attribute the final citation directly to publishing domains.

Under current international copyright laws, specifically the Berne Convention, it is entirely legal for anyone to copy the underlying ideas, conceptual frameworks, or structural angles of all content, and it is impossible to sue anyone over those. Copyright law protects the specific expression of an idea, not the underlying idea, system, or conceptual framework itself.

Because of this legal gray area, we have dug into the topic more, and figured out a whole shady network of related companies marketing affiliates and then masking it as expert-picked.

How Big Media Networks Steal Search Traffic

When large media companies enter specific software topics, their main goal is making money by getting people to click paid links. Huge media networks that own dozens of websites use repetitive tricks to steal search traffic from independent companies.

The process starts when an independent developer creates an original software tool and publishes detailed technical documentation or conceptual guides explaining how it works. Search engine algorithms initially index these pages, recognize the unique value, and award them top rankings or feature them as primary answers in summary overviews.

Media tracking teams at big websites constantly monitor keywords using specialized analytics programs. Once they spot an independent page getting steady search visits, their staff quickly writes up a broad list using those exact search titles, adds tracking links for paid sponsors, and puts it on a big website that easily pushes the real options down the page.

Keyword Interception and Intent Hijacking

Large media groups employ content teams to track search queries gaining traction across indie developer blogs, software release pages, and user forums. When a specific phrase shows consistent search interest, publishers generate broad roundup articles explicitly titled after those exact high-intent queries.

Rather than conducting independent testing or evaluating specialized native tools, these articles assemble generic overviews of heavily commercialized software suites. The intent is not to inform the reader about specialized software options, but to occupy the top organic search spots for general software queries.

The Affiliate Link Routing Model

A core element of this ecosystem is the systematic placement of affiliate tracking parameters across every recommended product.

When an independent tool like FTI Studio offers a native, free desktop application without an affiliate program, big publishing networks have no financial reason to list it; it’s not sponsored. Their internal site setups favor tools that pay them money for every click. Industry standard suites and popular tablet apps get the top recommended slots because they have direct commission agreements or monetized redirect links, while free tools with zero affiliate potential get pushed down or completely left out.

Domain Authority Exploitation and Search Attribution

Search engine ranking algorithms rely heavily on domain history, backlink profiles, and site size. Large publisher networks leverage these metrics to bypass traditional content relevance checks. Parent companies run web networks that link back and forth to each other, creating fake trust signals that search engines treat as genuine authority. Listicles regularly update their publication date tags without making real changes to the writing, tricking search crawlers into treating old affiliate lists as newly updated research. Modern AI search scrapers read technical data and topic breakdowns from smaller sites, summarize the information, and then attach the source link to the highest-authority domain covering that topic, effectively scrubbing the original author from the result.

Masked Advertising and Consumer Misdirection

These publisher networks routinely market these pages under the guise of neutral, expert-driven journalism. Prominent headers claim that selections are chosen by hands-on industry reviewers. However, small fine-print disclaimers at the top or bottom of the page reveal that the publisher receives financial compensation when readers click links or make purchases.

By framing monetized ad space as objective editorial recommendations, these networks mislead users searching for genuine software options while systematically suppressing independent tools that do not participate in commercial affiliate networks.